

Hearts and Minds

Sixteen years after he risked his life to save a little girl, an army officer returns to a homecoming in Manipur



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MASEBILU FELICITATES PILLAY IN MANIPUR

By Sandeep Unnithan

Sixteen years ago, Padma Kumar Pillay, a wiry 27-year-old army captain, kicked down the door of a hut in Manipur to be greeted by a burst of AK-47 fire and a grenade. Leading his men on a combating operation in Longbi Pabram village of Tamenglong district, the young soldier had surprised a group of Naga insurgents. The ensuing fight led to a militant escaping and two surrendering. Four bullets passed through Pillay's chest and shoulder, and his foot was injured in the grenade blast. Fearing the worst, his 30-member platoon recorded a message for his parents on a walkman.

Two others had been caught in the crossfire. Thirteen-year-old Masebilu had been shot in her stomach and her six-year-old nephew Dingamang also suffered injuries. Masebilu would not have survived the eight-hour trek downhill to the Tamenglong Civil Hospital. An army Cheetah helicopter flew in to evacuate the grievously wounded officer. Pillay, however, refused to fly out. Instead, he insisted that the little girl be flown out first to the hospital. The four-seater returned later for Pillay.

Little Masebilu and her brother survived, but not

hearing from the officer after the incident, the villagers presumed he had died. They prayed for the man who had saved two of their own. It was an act seemingly unprecedented in a state where the army's human rights record has been tainted by the massacre of 10 civilians by Assam Rifles personnel in 2000. The incident was followed by a nine-year fast by Irom Sharmila demanding the repeal of the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958. Longbi Pabram village has, however, stopped harbouring militants. Recently, on learning that Pillay was indeed alive and posted in Delhi, the villagers organised a reception.

Cut to March 12 when Lt Colonel Pillay, now 42, responded to the invitation and trekked back to a grateful village. There wasn't a dry eye as Pillay was re-united with Masebilu, now a healthy mother of two and Dingamang, a college student in Imphal. Pillay even hugged his assailants. "Love and forgiveness conquers more people than all the armies of the world," Pillay says. The army has adopted the village, giving it a playground, solar lights and is now constructing a road named after Masebilu. A fitting finale to a saga of compassion. ■